

Speaking

Detectives of the Past

Groups of 3-4 · 10 min

In groups, look at a short mystery situation (e.g. a broken window, a missing notebook, a surprise party ruined) and discuss what might have, must have, or couldn't have happened, giving reasons for your guesses.

Useful language: It must have been..., It might have been..., It couldn't have been... because..., That would explain why..., I'm not so sure about that because...

1. In groups, choose one mystery situation from the teacher's list.
2. Brainstorm at least three possible explanations using might have.
3. Agree on the explanation you think is most likely (must have) and one you can rule out (couldn't have).
4. Present your group's reasoning to the class in two minutes.

I Wish I Had Said Something

Pairs · 8 min

In pairs, take turns describing a real or invented situation where you feel you should have or could have acted differently, while your partner gives gentle advice or agrees with your reflection.

Useful language: I should have..., I could have..., Looking back, I shouldn't have..., In your place, I might have..., It's understandable that you...

1. Think of a small past situation (a missed chance, a small conflict, an unfinished task).
2. Share it with your partner using should have / could have to express what you would do differently now.
3. Your partner listens and responds with a supportive comment or their own similar experience.
4. Swap roles and repeat.

Writing

A Letter I Never Sent

120-150 words

Write a short letter to someone (a friend, family member, or classmate) explaining a past situation you regret and what you should have or could have done differently.

Plan:

1. Decide who the letter is to and what the situation was.
2. List 2-3 things you regret or should have done.
3. Think about how the situation made you feel and what you learned.
4. Plan a closing line that shows how you feel now.

Checklist:

- ☐ I used should have / shouldn't have / could have correctly.
- ☐ I explained the situation clearly.
- ☐ I included how I feel now.
- ☐ My letter is within the word limit.

The Mystery of the Missing Gift

130-160 words

Write a short paragraph speculating about what happened to a missing item (e.g. a birthday gift, a phone, a set of keys), using might have, must have, and couldn't have to explain different theories.

Plan:

1. Decide what item is missing and where it was last seen.
2. Brainstorm at least three possible explanations.
3. Order your ideas from least to most likely.
4. End with the explanation you believe is most probable.

Checklist:

- ☐ I included at least three different modal perfect structures.
- ☐ My guesses are logical and based on clues.
- ☐ I reached a clear conclusion at the end.
- ☐ My paragraph is within the word limit.